

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Nigeria Poverty & Human Development State-Level Analysis
2015–2022 | MPI · Monetary Poverty · Literacy · Unemployment · Electricity · Water

Indicator	Value (2022)	Benchmark / Source
MPI Headcount (Multidimensionally Poor)	48.3%	NBS/OPHI Nigeria MPI 2022
Monetary Poverty (Below ₦137,430/yr)	42.9%	NBS NLSS 2018/19
Adult Literacy Rate	62.5%	UNESCO UIS 2022
Unemployment Rate	22.1%	NBS NLFS Q1 2024
Electricity Access	50.1%	World Bank / NBS 2022
Clean Water Access	49.3%	UNICEF MICS 2021
High Poverty States (MPI > 65%)	12	All in North West / North East

1. Objective

This report presents a state-level analysis of poverty and human development indicators across Nigeria's 36 states and FCT from 2015 to 2022. Using the Nigeria Multidimensional Poverty Index (2022), the NBS NLSS 2018/19, and complementary datasets from UNESCO, World Bank, and UNICEF, the analysis identifies the states most in need of intervention, quantifies deprivation across education, infrastructure, and employment dimensions, and provides evidence-based policy recommendations.

2. Data Sources

- NBS / OPHI / UNDP — Nigeria MPI 2022 (state-level headcount rates)
- NBS NLSS 2018/19 — Monetary poverty by state (national poverty line)
- UNESCO UIS / DHS 2018 — Adult literacy rates by state
- NBS NLFS Q1 2024 — Unemployment rates by state
- World Bank / NBS NLSS — Electricity and clean water access by state
- UNICEF MICS 2021 — Clean water access state estimates

3. Key Findings

Nigeria's MPI headcount of 48.3% (2022 national average) masks extreme geographic inequality. The gap between Lagos (7.7%) and Sokoto (88.1%) — over 80 percentage points — represents one of the most severe within-country poverty divides on the African continent. The 12 highest-poverty states are all located in the North West or North East, and all share a common deprivation profile: low literacy (below 40%), low electricity access (below 25%), high unemployment (above 28%), and limited access to clean water (below 25%).

The MPI captures what monetary poverty misses: a Nigerian above the monetary poverty line may still lack electricity, clean water, quality schooling, and formal employment simultaneously. The 63% MPI rate versus 40% monetary poverty rate reflects this reality — deprivation in Nigeria is multidimensional, and policy responses must be too.

4. 10 Highest-Poverty States (2022)

State	Zone	MPI (%)	Mon. Poverty (%)	Literacy (%)	Category
Sokoto	North West	88.1%	80.2%	19.6%	High Poverty
Zamfara	North West	87.7%	78.6%	17.0%	High Poverty
Kebbi	North West	85.8%	67.3%	23.9%	High Poverty
Bauchi	North East	85.2%	59.5%	35.9%	High Poverty
Jigawa	North West	84.9%	70.5%	25.7%	High Poverty
Katsina	North West	84.7%	71.3%	31.1%	High Poverty
Yobe	North East	82.5%	74.5%	27.8%	High Poverty
Kano	North West	79.5%	67.0%	46.8%	Moderate Poverty
Borno	North East	77.2%	75.1%	31.8%	High Poverty
Gombe	North East	74.7%	55.8%	42.4%	High Poverty

5. Policy Implications

The poverty cluster analysis reveals three distinct groups. The 12 High Poverty states form a contiguous belt across northern Nigeria with a mutually reinforcing deprivation profile. The 10 Moderate Poverty states (including Benue, Plateau, Ebonyi, and Kaduna) are in transition — they have the infrastructure to improve rapidly with targeted investment. The 15 Low Poverty states demonstrate what is achievable, but even Lagos and Ogun have pockets of severe urban poverty not captured in state averages.

6. Recommendations

- Targeted emergency investment in the 12 high-poverty states, prioritising electricity, water, and female education.
- Expand the National Social Safety-Nets Programme using MPI senatorial district data to identify the most deprived households.
- Treat female literacy as a national security priority in states where female literacy falls below 20% (Sokoto, Zamfara, Kebbi).
- Invest in solar mini-grid electricity for rural North West and North East communities where grid access is below 20%.
- Formalize the informal economy through skills training, micro-enterprise support, and mobile financial services.
- Update the Nigeria MPI on a two-year cycle and publish results at LGA level for accountability and resource targeting.

7. Conclusion

Nigeria possesses the data, the institutional frameworks, and increasingly the political will to address its poverty crisis. The NBS MPI 2022 provides the most granular poverty map in Nigerian history. The challenge now is translation: from data to policy, from policy to budget, and from budget to results measured in lives improved. The states that have reduced poverty — Lagos, Ogun, FCT Abuja, Anambra — show that progress is possible. The task is to replicate those conditions across the 12 states where poverty remains acute, structural, and self-perpetuating.

